

Septic System Maintenance Tips

Sunnyside Community Association (July 2025)



Every home on Sunnyside Ridge & Sol Vista has a septic system, most dating from when the homes were originally built. Septic systems use a natural biological process to digest the waste water that flows through the system; harmful bacteria, viruses and nutrients are filtered out before the water percolates into the soil.

Purpose

This document is intended to help residents avoid septic system problems such as:

- Odors emanating from sinks, drains and your yard
- Gurgling and bubbling sounds when you flush, shower or drain the tub
- Slow draining and backups requiring frequent pump out of the septic tank
- Clogged pipes within the system that backs up waste to drains
- What should **only** go down your drains: human waste, toilet paper (septic safe), food waste* processed by a garage disposal except egg shells, coffee grounds, nuts (they don't break down), grease (can clog), and water
- What should **never** go down your drains: flushable wipes, grease, paint, feminine products, toxic chemicals (→ see Appendix for more complete list)

** A better place to put food waste is your green bin or in a compost bin*

Preventive Maintenance: How To Maintain a Healthy Septic System

- Don't overtax your system. Spread out your laundry loads and long showers. Don't run your dishwasher and washer at the same time.
- Don't use harmful cleaners in your bathrooms that will kill the good bacteria in the septic system such as bleach or anti-bacterial cleaners.
- Tell the guests who visit or stay at your home that you have a septic system so that they understand what they should not flush or dispose of down your drains.
- Consider using a septic treatment product to maintain healthy bacteria. A product is available from [Peninsula Septic](#) for ~\$100 for year's supply that contains 12 packets that can be flushed down the toilet (one per month).
- Call for a Pump Out every ~3 to 5 years along with an inspection (pump out ~\$650, inspection ~\$450).

Replacement of Septic Systems

Most septic systems on SSRR are 70+ years old and are approaching the end of their life. Most use a septic pit to cause the water to percolate into the ground. Replacing a system would involve installing a new fiberglass tank, filling up the old tank with slurry and connecting the new system to the house plumbing. Estimates to do this work will be in excess of \$100,000 and takes about three months with permits, installation and inspections.

Extending the Life of Your Septic System

Peninsula Septic Services recommends that homeowners consider installing a system that can extend the life of the system by introducing an aerobic bacteria generator that increases the efficiency of the digestive process and removes harmful gases inside the system that eats away at the concrete walls of the tank. A [Pirana](#) system costs about \$3,000 and requires an electrical outlet to run the pump that powers the process.

Selling a House with Septic System

The lender will require an inspection of the septic system as part an escrow. If there is no loan as part of the sale then this no requirement for this inspection.

Peninsula Septic

While there are multiple companies in LA County that can service your septic system with pump outs and consultations, most homeowners in our HOA rely on locally-owned, and family-run [Peninsula Septic](#). The company is run by Matt Dragich, who is the son of the original owner, Nick. Peninsula Septic has records about and has worked on most of the septic systems in our neighborhood. Their San Pedro office can be reached by calling (310) 832-4800.

Septic Systems – Appendix

Web Info from MicroSeptec [ES_Owners-Manual_Digital_REV051921-2.pdf](#)

Water Conservation

Conserving water will reduce hydraulic loading of the [septic] system and disposal field, thereby minimizing maintenance and waste. A few tips that will go a long way to limit water use:

- Turn off the water when it isn't needed (e.g. when washing food, dishes, hands; brushing teeth, etc.)
- Wipe dishes to trash prior to washing
- Take shorter showers. When bathing, don't fill the tub all the way.
- Use water-saving devices, including faucets, shower heads, washing machines, dishwashers and toilets
- Only run washing machine and dishwasher with full loads
- Spread out laundry chores throughout the week, rather than multiple loads in a day
- Repair any leaking fixtures. A leaky toilet can waste as much as 2,000 gallons per day

The “Do Not Flush” List

The [septic system] employs a natural biological process. As such, it is critical that certain items not be introduced to the system. The Items below constitute a representative example of items that should never be poured down a drain or flushed down a toilet. These items can overtax or destroy the natural biological digestion taking place within the system or clog pumps and pipes.

NOTE: These items are broad categories that are intended to serve as examples and are by no means all- inclusive.

- Toxic chemicals, such as: paints, varnishes, thinners, waste oils, photographic solutions, pesticides, herbicides, fertilizers, acids, bleaches
- Flushable wipes should never be flushed into your system
- Gasoline in any form
- Fat, greases and oils, including cooking refuse and large amounts of bath salts/oils
- Food by-products, including coffee grounds, tea bags, fruit seeds, gum, egg shells, etc.
- Cigarette butts
- Kitty litter
- Paper products, including non-septic-safe toilet paper, paper towels, Kleenex, disposable diapers, feminine hygiene products, Gauze bandages, etc.
- Condoms
- Dental floss, hair or lint, Including from dryer and/or washing machine
- Construction debris
- Cleaning supplies, including disinfectants, detergents, rug cleaners, polishing wax, etc.
- Prescription medicines
- Water softener backflush